

The Rise of Man-Made Systems

From the beginning, sin introduced uncertainty into the human experience. When humanity lost trust in God, fear took its place. Fear, in turn, demands control, and control leads people to build systems. Genesis 3 captures this shift when Adam says, *“I was afraid... so I hid.”* Fear pushes people to ask: Am I safe? Am I accepted? Am I right? Instead of resting in God’s righteousness, humans attempt to manufacture their own.

This pattern repeats throughout history. Uncertainty leads to systems, systems shape culture, culture defines a “path to the good life,” and those systems are enforced against anyone who questions them. The Pharisees are a clear example. After centuries without prophetic guidance, they believed that perfect obedience to all 613 laws would force God’s hand and restore Israel. Their theological systems became cultural identity, enforced as righteousness.

Because religious leaders like the Levites were socially insulated and did not experience the consequences of their teachings, they could impose heavy burdens on others without feeling their weight. Jesus directly confronted this hypocrisy, noting how leaders placed crushing demands on people while refusing to help carry them.

The same pattern can appear in the Church today. Communities may silence truth-tellers because they create discomfort. Over time, this leads to a culture disconnected from reality. When leaders confuse God’s Word with their interpretations of it, human reasoning becomes codified as divine truth. This creates harm, benefits some, and elevates man-made systems to a place only God should hold.

The solution is not more certainty through systems, but deeper security in Christ. We must prioritize relationship over control, humility over certainty, and Christ Himself as Truth. Systems feel safe and logical, but relationships are messy and uncertain. Yet they are where spiritual life, meaning, and God’s blessing are found.